FIELD GUIDE 03 · ATHLETICS & COACHING

EB-1A

for Athletes & Coaches

PODIUM TO PERMANENCE

A premium guide for elite competitors, coaches, and performance directors building a self-petitioned extraordinary ability case

AiVass

Published by AiVass LLC

PURPOSE. PROOF. PERMANENCE.

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Edition 1.0 · Legal standards verified July 2026

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Before You Begin

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WHERE THIS GUIDE SITS

This is a **field guide**. The **AiVass EB-1A Master Guide** covers the full legal framework and all ten criteria in general terms; Chapter 2 here restates the essentials so this guide stands alone. Everything else addresses one reality: an athletic career is short, its records live with federations and press rather than in your desk drawer, and the most consequential decision you will make — **whether you file as an athlete or as a coach** — is made before you write a single page.

How to Use This Guide

- **Beginner — "Is my level high enough?"** Chapters 1–3 and the self-assessment in Chapter 12.
- **Advanced — "How do I document a career that lived on a field?"** Chapters 4–9. The transition rule, medals and team awards, rankings, contracts, roles, and the sprint plan.
- **Expert / B2B — "How do we run athletics cases?"** Chapter 11. Intake, federation evidence sourcing, exhibit architecture, and the athletics RFE register.

THE THREE BOXES

Straight from the source

Blue boxes carry the controlling authority — statute, regulation, or the USCIS Policy Manual.

Strategy note

Gold boxes carry AiVass strategy: how strong athletics cases are positioned, and where weak ones fall apart.

The bottom line

Navy boxes distill the chapter into the one thing to remember.

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CHAPTER
01

Athletics Is a Named Field

And the clock is the thing nobody tells you about.

Athletics is one of the five statutory fields in INA § 203(b)(1)(A) — equal in law to the sciences, arts, education, and business. Nothing in the regulation ranks them, and nothing requires an Olympic medal. The regulation's own language asks for **"lesser nationally or internationally recognized prizes or awards"** — the word **lesser** is doing deliberate work.

What the category offers an athletic career

- **Self-petition.** No club, federation, or employer sponsors you. You file your own Form I-140.
- **No job offer, no PERM.** The Policy Manual confirms an EB-1A petition "does not need to be supported by a job offer." No labor-market test.
- **Independence from a contract.** For athletes whose status is tied to a P-1 or O-1 held through a team, permanent residence ends the dependency — including through injury, trade, or retirement.
- **First preference.** Current for most countries, with premium processing available.

The clock nobody mentions

Every other field can build acclaim for decades. Athletics compresses it. Your peak is measurable, dated, and — for most disciplines — behind you by your mid-thirties. The regulation does not care about your age. But it does require **sustained** acclaim, and the Policy Manual instructs officers to ask whether you **"continue to maintain a comparable level of acclaim"** since the original recognition.

> **Strategy note — the two-window rule**
>
> Athletics petitions have two evidentiary windows. The peak window supplies the achievements. The recent window — roughly the last 24 months — supplies the proof they were sustained. A petition strong in the first and empty in the second is the classic athletics denial. Chapter 9 shows you how to fill the second window whether you are still competing, coaching, officiating, or advising.

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Who this guide is for

- Current professional and national-team athletes across all disciplines.
- Recently retired competitors, including those transitioning into coaching or sport administration.
- Head coaches, assistant coaches, and technical directors at national or top professional level.
- Performance directors, sports scientists, physiotherapists, and analysts embedded in elite programs.
- Referees, judges, and technical officials certified at international level.
- Athletes and coaches in emerging or non-Olympic sports — where proving national recognition takes extra work, and is entirely possible.

Who it is not for — yet

Strong club-level competition, age-group titles, and collegiate success are real achievements that generally sit **below** the national-acclaim line. You are not disqualified; you are early. Chapter 3 shows you exactly where the line sits, and Chapter 9 gives you a build plan.

> **The bottom line**
>
> Athletics is a named field with a compressed clock. The medals prove the peak. The last 24 months prove it was sustained. You need both.

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CHAPTER

02

The Standard in Plain English

Three prongs, one definition, two steps.

The three prongs

> **Straight from the source**
>
> **1.** Extraordinary ability in athletics, demonstrated by **sustained national or international acclaim**, with achievements recognized through extensive documentation.
>
> **2.** Intent to **continue working in your area of extraordinary ability** in the United States.
>
> **3.** Your entry will **substantially benefit the United States** in the future.
>
> *— INA § 203(b)(1)(A); USCIS Policy Manual, Vol. 6, Pt. F, Ch. 2*

Prong 3 has a famous athletics answer. The Policy Manual's own illustration of the broad "substantial benefit" reading is **Matter of Price** — a professional golfer, where the benefit was found in the sport's popularity and the athlete's contribution to it. Officers interpret this prong broadly and case-by-case.

The definition

> **Straight from the source**
>
> "A level of expertise indicating that the individual is **one of that small percentage who have risen to the very top of the field of endeavor**." — 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(2)

For athletes, the definition maps unusually cleanly onto reality: rankings, results, medals, and contracts already sort your field into tiers. Your task is less about arguing that you are near the top and more about **documenting the tier itself** — with federation records, not assertions.

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Two pathways in

- **Pathway A — one-time achievement.** A major, internationally recognized award. In athletics, an Olympic gold medal is the paradigm case. There is no comparable-evidence substitute for this pathway.
- **Pathway B — three of ten criteria.** The road most athletes travel, including many Olympians. Meet at least three — or evidence properly argued as comparable to them.

Then: the two-step test

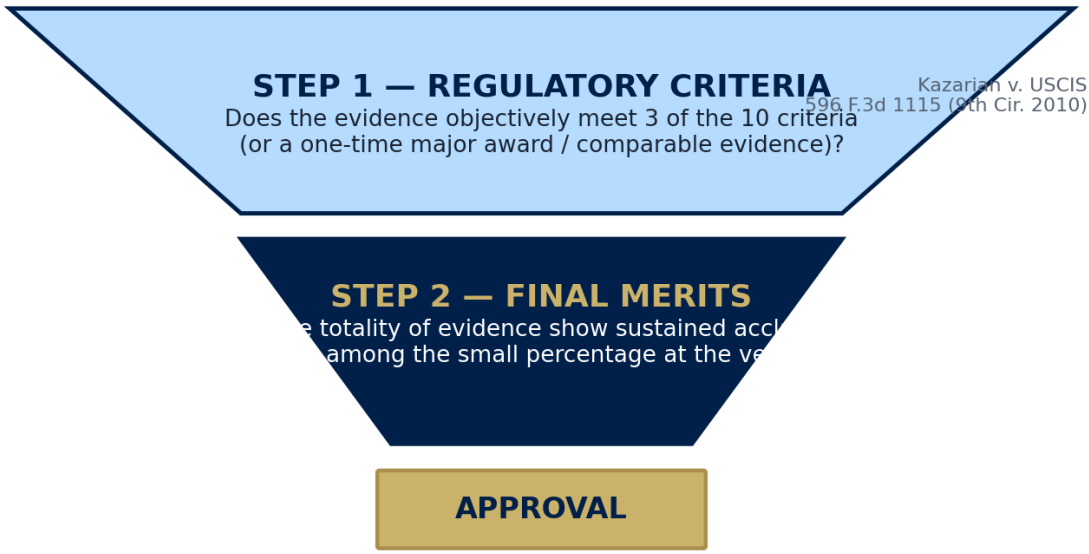


Figure 2.1 — The Kazarian two-step analysis.

Step 1: do your documents objectively meet three criteria? Step 2: does the **totality** show you among the small percentage at the very top, with acclaim that is national or international rather than local? This is where rankings, records, and press do their heaviest work — none of them is a criterion, and all of them matter enormously.

Three rules that shape athletics cases

- **Sustained means maintained.** The compressed clock makes this the field's defining challenge.
- **No age limit, in either direction.** The Manual states a person "may be very young or early in his or her career and still be able to show sustained acclaim." Rookie-of-the-year awards in major leagues are its own example of a qualifying honor.

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- **Letters are not the cornerstone.** Coach and federation letters matter — but they must be corroborated by documents, and acclaim must extend beyond your personal and professional acquaintances.

The bottom line

Your results already sort your field. The petition's job is to prove the sorting to someone who has never watched your sport.

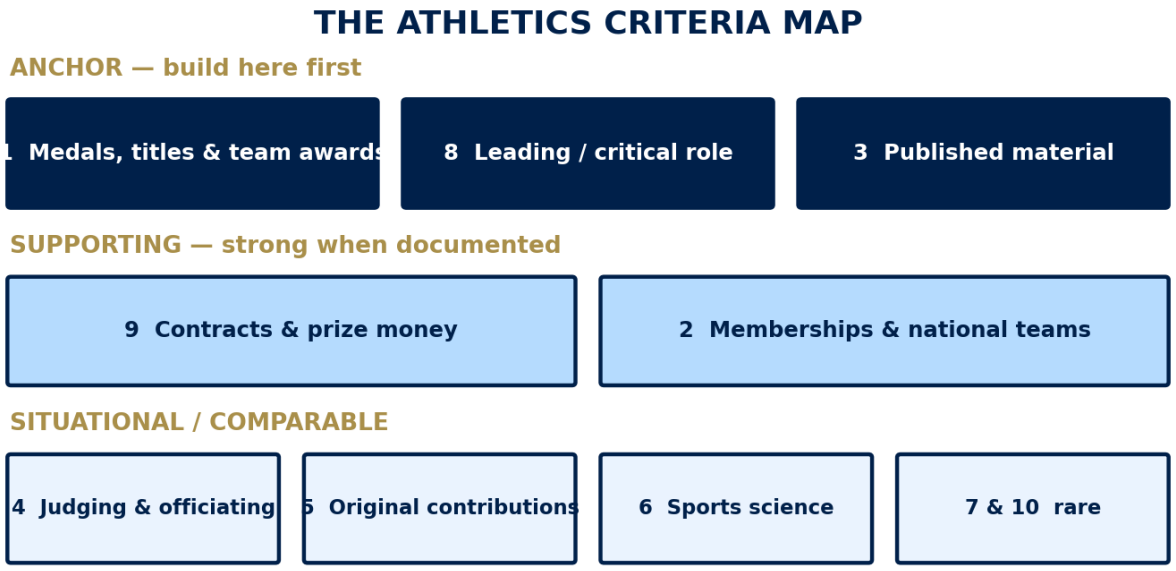
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CHAPTER

03

The Athletics Criteria Map

Where competitive careers become evidence.



Rankings and records are not a criterion — they are Step 2 evidence, and they are decisive there.

Figure 3.1 — The Athletics Criteria Map. Anchor first, support second, situational last.

The three anchors

- **Criterion 1 — prizes and awards.** Medals, championships, league honors — and, since October 2024, team awards where you are a named recipient. The athletics anchor. Chapter 5.
- **Criterion 8 — leading or critical role.** Captaincy, starter status on a nationally ranked team, head coach or performance director of a distinguished program, or a critical specialist role. Chapter 7.
- **Criterion 3 — published material about you.** Match reports that analyze your performance, national-daily profiles, broadcast features. Chapter 6.

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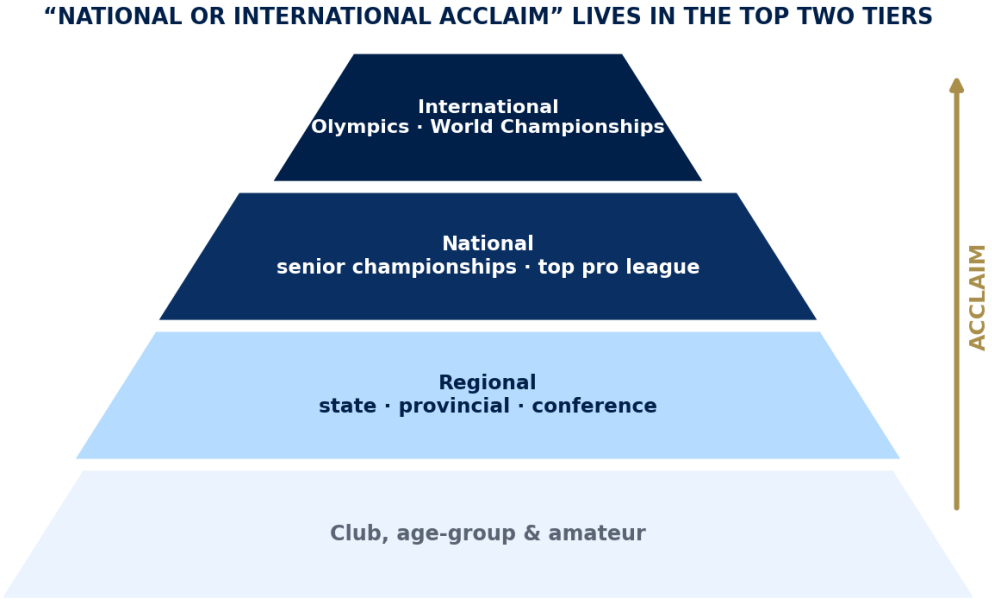
The two supports

- **Criterion 9 — contracts and prize money.** Federation money lists are the cleanest percentile evidence available in any field. League salary distributions do the same job. Chapter 6.
- **Criterion 2 — memberships.** Halls of fame elected by expert panels; national-team selection framed with the selection committee's documented standards; elite athlete commissions. Chapter 7.

The situationals

- **Criterion 4 — judging and officiating.** Certified international referee or judge at sanctioned events; national-team selection committees; technical delegate roles. Buildable, and unusually strong for transitioning athletes.
- **Criterion 5 — original contributions.** A training methodology adopted by national programs; a technique or rule change traced to you. Rare, powerful, and hard to prove.
- **Criterion 6 — scholarly articles.** Sports-science publications; federation technical manuals written for learned practitioners. A comparable-evidence candidate for most.
- **Criteria 7 & 10.** Not applicable as written. Do not force them.

Where the national-acclaim line sits



Youth, rookie, and amateur awards can still qualify if nationally recognized — prove the recognition.

Figure 3.2 — Acclaim is national or international, not regional or club-level.

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Two nuances save real cases. First, awards limited to **youth, amateurs, or rookies** can still qualify if they are nationally or internationally recognized — the Manual says so explicitly. Second, **niche and emerging sports** are not excluded: you must simply do the work of proving that your discipline's national championship is nationally recognized, using federation charters, media coverage, and government sport-ministry recognition.

Rankings and records — not a criterion, and decisive anyway

There is no "world ranking" criterion. Rankings, national records, and head-to-head results are **Step 2 evidence** — and at Step 2 the officer considers any relevant evidence, even material that fits no criterion. A documented top-20 world ranking sustained across three seasons will do more for your final-merits determination than a marginal ninth criterion. File it. Explain it. Source it to the federation.

> **The bottom line**
>
> Anchor on 1, 8, and 3. Support with 9 and 2. Then let rankings and records win Step 2.

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CHAPTER

04

The Transition Rule

Athlete or coach? The single most consequential decision in your petition.

USCIS treats the athlete-to-coach move as its own analytical problem — and gets asked about it constantly, because athletic careers end while coaching careers begin. Prong 2 requires you to **continue working in the area of your extraordinary ability**. Competing and coaching are not obviously the same area. The Manual resolves it with a rule you must plan around, not discover in an RFE.

> **Straight from the source — the transition analysis**
>
> Where a person has achieved recent national or international acclaim as an athlete and has sustained that acclaim in the field of coaching or managing at a national level, officers may consider the totality of the evidence as establishing an overall pattern of sustained acclaim and extraordinary ability — such that coaching is within the person's area of expertise.
>
> Where substantial time has passed since the person competed, officers may weigh the coaching record itself, potentially exclusively.
>
> *— USCIS Policy Manual, Vol. 6, Pt. F, Ch. 2 (accessed July 2026)*

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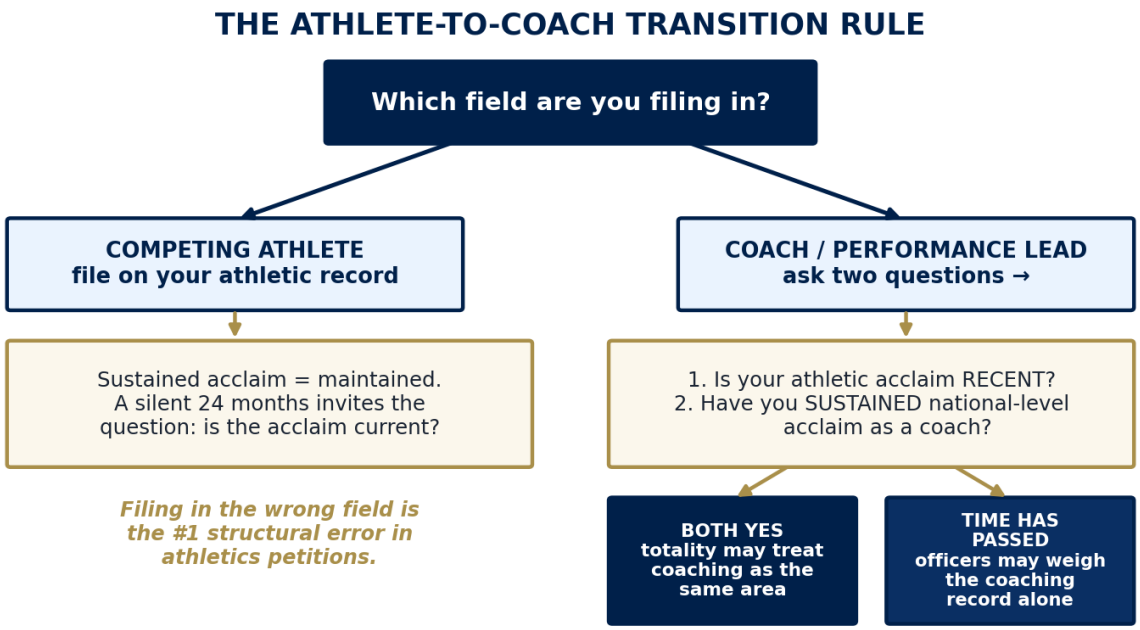


Figure 4.1 — The transition decision tree. Answer it before you draft anything.

Reading the rule correctly

1. **Recent athletic acclaim + sustained national-level coaching acclaim.** The strongest posture. You may present one continuous area of expertise and draw on both records. The word carrying the weight is “sustained”: national-level coaching acclaim, evidenced, not merely a coaching job.
2. **Substantial time since competing.** Your athletic record becomes context. The coaching record must stand largely on its own — coaching honors, athletes developed to national or international level, federation appointments, coverage of your methods.
3. **Recent athletic acclaim, no coaching record yet.** File as an athlete. Do not claim a coaching field you have not yet built.
4. **Neither record is national.** You are early. Build (Chapter 9).

One more rule worth knowing

The Manual addresses a related question directly: acclaim earned competing in men’s sports is **not** treated as continuing work in the same area when the intended U.S. work is competition in women’s sports. The underlying principle generalizes: the area of expertise is defined by where the acclaim was actually earned. Officers apply that principle consistently, so plan your field definition around the record you actually have.

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Writing the coach's field of endeavor

The AiVass field formula

[Coaching discipline] + [sport / event group] + [level]

"High-performance sprint coaching at national-team level." · "Technical direction and player development in professional men's football." · "Elite-level artistic gymnastics coaching, senior international competition."

- Name the level explicitly — "national team," "top professional division," "senior international." It is the tier your acclaim must match.
- Do not write "sports" or "athletics." The peer group becomes everyone, and the top few percent becomes unreachable.
- Use the identical phrase in every criterion section, every letter brief, and the final-merits argument.
- Verify Prong 2: the field you claim must be the field you intend to continue in the United States. If you will coach here, your evidence must show coaching acclaim.

Building the coach's record

- **Athletes developed.** Named athletes, their results before and after you, and the federation records proving both. This is the coach's equivalent of a citation count.
- **Appointments.** National-team appointments, federation technical roles, Olympic or World Championship staff credentials.
- **Honors.** Coach-of-the-year awards, federation commendations, hall-of-fame election — with the award dossier (Chapter 5).
- **Method coverage.** Press or technical publications discussing your training methodology, not just your team's results.
- **Officiating and selection.** Certified officiating and national selection-committee service — Criterion 4 evidence that also proves standing.

RFE radar — the wrong-field filing

The most common structural error in athletics petitions is filing an athlete's evidence for a coach's intended work, or vice versa. It is not a documentation problem — it is a Prong 2 problem, and it is expensive. Decide your field, then gather. Never the reverse.

The bottom line

Recent athletic acclaim plus sustained national coaching acclaim can be one area. Everything else means you file on the record you actually have — and build the other one first.

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CHAPTER

05

Medals, Titles & Team Awards

Criterion 1 — the athletics anchor.

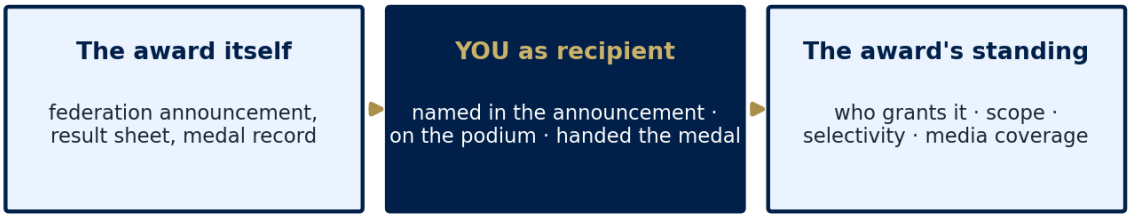
> **In the regulation — 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(i)**
>
> *"Documentation of the alien's receipt of lesser nationally or internationally recognized prizes or awards for excellence in the field of endeavor."*

Two questions, in order. Did **you** receive it? And is the award **nationally or internationally recognized for excellence in the field**? Note what is absent: any requirement that the award be the highest one available. "Lesser" is the regulation's own word.

Team awards — the October 2024 change

For decades, athletes on the podium with teammates were told their medals were the team's, not theirs. USCIS has now stated the position plainly: **team awards can qualify where the person is an actual recipient of the prize or award** — named in the announcement, standing on the podium, handed the medal, trophy, or certificate.

TEAM AWARDS — PROVING INDIVIDUAL RECEIPT (post-October 2024)



USCIS now states team awards can qualify where the person is an actual recipient.

A roster listing alone is not receipt. Find the document that names you.

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Figure 5.1 — Proving individual receipt of a team honor.

The evidentiary burden shifts accordingly. A roster listing is **not** receipt. Find the federation announcement that names you, the results sheet recording your leg or position, the medal record, the podium photograph with a caption. Relay swimmers, rowers, football squads, and relay-team sprinters: this paragraph is your case.

What qualifies across athletics

- Olympic, World Championship, and continental championship medals — individual and team.
- National senior championship titles.
- Top professional league honors: MVP, golden boot, all-league selections, and — per the Manual's own example — rookie-of-the-year awards.
- Major international tour or circuit victories, with the event's standing documented.
- National records ratified by the governing federation (as award-adjacent evidence and powerful Step 2 material).
- Youth and junior world or continental titles, where the award is nationally or internationally recognized.

What does not

- Club championships, regional titles, and age-group awards below national recognition.
- Participation medals and finisher awards.
- Awards where entry required a fee and selectivity cannot be documented.
- Team honors where nothing names you individually.

The award dossier

Officers do not know your sport. Build one page per award. This is the highest-return document in an athletics petition.

Element	What to file
Your receipt	Federation announcement naming you; medal record; results sheet; podium photograph with caption
The granting body	Federation charter, national or international recognition, government sport-ministry status
Selectivity	Field size, qualifying standards, number of competitors versus medalists

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Element	What to file
Recognition	Independent media coverage of the competition and the award; broadcast reach
Standing	Prominence of past winners; the event's place in the sport's calendar

Strategy note — niche and emerging sports

If your discipline is not broadly covered by international media, do not concede national recognition — prove it. Federation charters, national olympic committee recognition, sport-ministry funding, televised finals, and national-team status are all documentary evidence that a national championship in your sport is nationally recognized. The work is heavier. The result is the same.

Criterion 1 self-check

- ☐ A document from the awarding body names me individually as a recipient.
- ☐ For team honors: I hold the announcement, results sheet, or medal record naming me.
- ☐ The award dossier proves the granting body's national or international standing.
- ☐ Selectivity — field size, qualifying standard, medals awarded — is documented.
- ☐ Independent media covered the competition and the award, not only my win.
- ☐ Foreign-language certificates and federation records have certified translations.

RFE radar

The number-one RFE attacks the award's recognition, not your receipt. The number-two attacks individual receipt on team honors. Both are documentation problems, and both are solved before filing by the award dossier.

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CHAPTER
06

Press, Contracts & Prize Money

Criterion 3 and Criterion 9 — coverage and compensation.

Criterion 3 — published material about you

> **In the regulation — 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(iii)**
>
> *"Published material about the alien in professional or major trade publications or other major media, relating to the alien's work in the field … Such evidence shall include the title, date, and author of the material, and any necessary translation."*

Athletes generate more press than any other EB-1A field and file it worse than anyone. The criterion requires material **about you, relating to your work** — you need not be the sole subject, and coverage of your team qualifies where you are mentioned in connection with the work or your significant role is documented. The outlet must be professional, major trade, or major media, judged by intended audience and by relative circulation, readership, or **viewership** — which is how broadcast coverage enters, as a transcript with audience data.

COUNTS VERSUS DOES NOT

Counts	Does not count
A match report analyzing your performance, by a named journalist	A box score or results table listing your name
A national-daily profile of your training, technique, or career	A transfer rumor or one-line quote
A broadcast feature segment, filed as transcript with viewership data	Your club's website or social media
Sports-trade coverage of your methods (coaches especially)	A press release, or a wire syndication of one
A federation or league publication feature about you	Any paid feature, sponsored post, or advertorial

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For every item, attach a one-page cover sheet: the passage discussing **you** (highlighted), the author, the date, and the outlet's credentials — circulation, readership, or viewership. Officers know the New York Times. They do not know which sports daily leads your country, or which trade title leads your discipline. Prove it with data.

Criterion 9 — contracts, prize money, and endorsements

> **In the regulation — 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(ix)**
>
> *"Evidence that the alien has commanded a high salary or other significantly high remuneration for services, in relation to others in the field."*

Athletics has an advantage no other field enjoys: **published money lists**. Federation and tour prize-money rankings are third-party, verifiable, and already sorted into percentiles. They are the single cleanest way to satisfy this criterion in any field.

THE FOUR-STEP BENCHMARK

1. Fix your comparator: the same discipline, the same competitive level, the same season or contract year.
2. Pull the distribution: the tour or federation money list, or the league's published salary distribution.
3. Compute your placement — aim to document top ~10%, and show the arithmetic.
4. Assemble total remuneration: contract, prize money, appearance fees, endorsements — each with the underlying document.

Two clarifications from the current Manual help athletes specifically. First, "has commanded" does **not** require money already earned: a credible signed contract showing prospective compensation can qualify — decisive for an athlete transferring to a U.S. club. Second, the comparison must be against **others in the field** — a rugby player is not benchmarked against footballers, and a domestic salary is not benchmarked against a foreign league.

> **Strategy note — when to skip Criterion 9**
>
> Many elite athletes in non-commercial sports earn modestly. That is a fact about the sport, not about you. If your compensation is ordinary against the right comparator, leave the criterion out: filing it invites an officer to write a paragraph about how you are not exceptional. Three strong criteria beat four with a soft one.

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Criterion 2 — memberships and national teams

The association — at the **grade you hold** — must require outstanding achievements, judged by recognized national or international experts. In athletics this includes halls of fame elected by expert panels, athlete commissions of national olympic committees, and — argued carefully — **national-team selection**, where you can document that the selection committee comprises recognized experts applying achievement-based standards. File the selection policy, name the committee, and show the standards. A roster spot without that documentation will not carry the criterion.

The bottom line

Your money list is a percentile. Your press is a reputation. Both are already public — your job is to file them the way an officer can verify them.

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CHAPTER

07

Roles, Judging & Original Contributions

Criteria 8, 4, and 5 — standing beyond results.

Criterion 8 — leading or critical role

> **In the regulation — 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(viii)**
>
> *"Evidence that the alien has performed in a leading or critical role for organizations or establishments that have a distinguished reputation."*

Two elements: a **leading OR critical** role — for an organization **or a division or department of one** — and that entity's **distinguished reputation**. It is the **performance, not the title**, that decides "critical," which is why a specialist can win this criterion without a captain's armband.

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE IN ATHLETICS

- **Leading —** captain of a nationally ranked team; head coach or technical director of a national program; performance director of an elite institute.
- **Critical —** a starter whose statistical contribution drove the team's season; a set-piece or position coach whose unit's outcomes changed measurably; a lead analyst or physiologist whose protocol produced documented performance gains.
- **The entity —** national federations, olympic committees, top-division clubs, nationally ranked programs, elite training institutes.

PROVING DISTINGUISHED REPUTATION

- League standing, national ranking, championships won, continental qualification.
- Attendance, broadcast reach, revenue, or federation funding.
- Independent press about the organization itself.

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- Longevity, honors, and the prominence of athletes it has produced.

THE BUT-FOR SENTENCE

Strategy note — write it first

"Without [name]'s [specific work], [organization] would not have [specific outcome], measured by [number]."

"Without Mr. Alvarenga's restructuring of the sprint-relay exchange protocol, the national team would not have set the national record or qualified for the World Championship final — its first in eleven years."

The regulation requires experience evidence to be letters from employers (8 C.F.R. § 204.5(g)(1)). For athletes, those come from clubs, federations, and national governing bodies. Brief them with metrics; never draft the letter.

Criterion 4 — judging and officiating

In the regulation — 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(iv)

"Evidence of the alien's participation, either individually or on a panel, as a judge of the work of others in the same or an allied field of specialization …"

Underused in athletics and unusually powerful for transitioning athletes. You must show you were invited **and** that you **actually completed** the judging.

- Certified judge or referee at sanctioned national or international competitions — file the certification and the event assignments.
- National-team selection committee service.
- Technical delegate or jury-of-appeal roles at championships.
- Coaching-license examination panels; federation technical committees evaluating others' performance.
- Grant or scholarship panels for athlete development programs.

Keep the appointment letter and the proof of completion — the assignment sheet, the official record, the certificate. Then build the prestige packet: the event's level, the number of competitors, the certifying body. Judging of any caliber satisfies Step 1; at Step 2 the officer asks whether it reflects top-of-field standing.

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Criterion 5 — original contributions of major significance

Rare in athletics and formidable when real. The regulation names **"athletic … contributions of major significance"** explicitly. Two elements: **original**, and of **major significance to the field** — not to one team.

WHAT QUALIFIES

- A training or conditioning methodology adopted by national programs beyond your own — with adoption letters and outcome data.
- A technique or tactical innovation that federations or coaching curricula credit to you.
- A rule change, safety protocol, or equipment innovation traced to your work and adopted by the governing body.
- Injury-reduction or performance protocols with published efficacy data, used outside your organization.

WHAT FAILS

- Exceptional performance itself — winning is Criterion 1 evidence, not an "original contribution."
- A method used only by your own team.
- Coach letters praising your innovation with no adopter named and no document behind it.

> **RFE radar**
>
> Officers concede originality and reject major significance. Build a Significance Map: what you originated → who outside your program adopted it → what document proves it → what changed, in numbers.

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CHAPTER

08

Rankings, Records & the Federation Evidence Engine

Winning Step 2 with the sport's own paperwork.

No criterion says "world ranking." And yet rankings, records, and head-to-head results decide more athletics petitions than any single criterion — because at **Step 2** the officer weighs **any potentially relevant evidence**, including material that fits no criterion at all. Your sport already keeps this paperwork. Most petitioners never request it.

The federation evidence engine

Federations, leagues, and governing bodies hold the documents that convert your career into verifiable fact. Request them early — foreign federations are slow, and certified translation adds weeks.

Document	What it proves	Where to request
Official competition results and results sheets	Your placement, field size, competitive level	National federation; event organizer
Ranking history extracts	Sustained standing over seasons — the "sustained" prong	International federation / tour
Record ratification certificates	National or continental records held	Governing body
National-team selection records	Selection standards and committee composition	National olympic committee / federation
Prize-money or earnings lists	Percentile placement for Criterion 9	Tour, league, or federation
Officiating certifications and assignments	Criterion 4 completion proof	Certifying federation
Coaching licenses and	Coaching standing and level	Federation technical department

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Document	What it proves	Where to request
appointments		
Federation letters on standing	Distinguished reputation; your role	Secretary-general or technical director

Presenting rankings and records

1. Show the trajectory, not one snapshot: a season-by-season table of ranking, results, and competitive level.
2. Explain the ranking system in two sentences — how points accrue, how many athletes are ranked, what a given position means.
3. Cite the source for every row: federation database, official tour list, ratified record certificate.
4. Interpret it for the officer: “a sustained top-15 world ranking places Ms. Karim in approximately the top 2% of ranked athletes in her discipline.”

The recency window

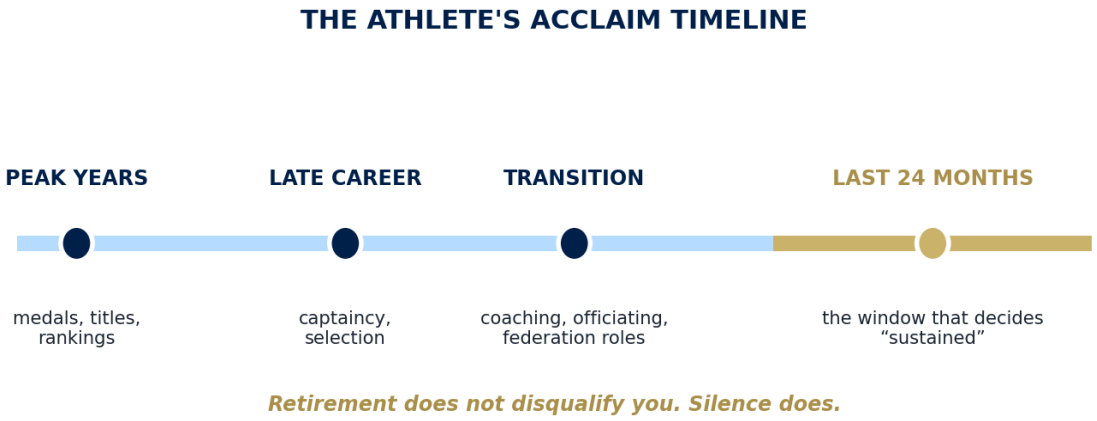


Figure 8.1 — Retirement does not disqualify you. Silence does.

Whatever your stage, fill the last 24 months with documented recognition. If you are still competing: results and coverage. If you are transitioning: coaching appointments, officiating assignments, federation roles, athletes developed, media on your methods. If you are advising: technical committee service, published protocols, program leadership. The Manual asks whether you **continue to maintain a comparable level of acclaim**. Answer it with dates.

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The intent evidence

No job offer is required — but Prong 2 requires intent to continue in your area of expertise. Athletics-specific evidence of intent:

- A signed contract, letter of intent, or term sheet with a U.S. club, league, or program.
- Coaching appointment letters or invitations from U.S. federations, clubs, or academies.
- Officiating assignments or certifications recognized by U.S. governing bodies.
- A personal statement describing your intended competitive, coaching, or technical work in the United States.
- Where you will operate independently — clinics, an academy, a training business — a business plan.

The bottom line

Your federation is holding your petition. Request the records, explain the systems, and let the sport's own paperwork win Step 2.

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CHAPTER
09

Final Merits & the Evidence Sprint

From five checkmarks to one verdict — in 180 days.

Winning Step 2

You meet four or five criteria. Nothing is decided. Step 2 weighs the **totality** and asks whether you sit among the small percentage at the very top, with acclaim that is national or international and **sustained**. Athletics petitions win Step 2 by translating the sport into terms an officer can weigh.

THE FINAL-MERITS ARGUMENT, IN SEVEN MOVES

1. Restate the standard — the two-step framework and the "small percentage at the very top" definition.
2. Define the peer group concretely — who is the top few percent of your discipline? Name the competitions, rankings, and tiers that mark it.
3. Establish the level — explain your sport's competitive structure, and where your results sit within it.
4. Synthesize, do not repeat — one arc: results → standing → influence.
5. Place yourself with comparatives — ranking percentile, medals per field size, earnings percentile, athletes developed.
6. Prove the acclaim is national or international — federation records, national press, international competition.
7. Show the trajectory is alive, then land the U.S. benefit: what your competing, coaching, or technical work contributes here.

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Letters — the independence rule

The Manual says witness statements "should not form the cornerstone" of the claim, must be corroborated by documents, and that acclaim should extend **beyond your personal and professional acquaintances**. For athletics:

- Six to eight letters, majority independent — rival federation officials, national coaches you did not work under, sports scientists, journalists of standing.
- Establish each writer's own credentials before their opinion of you.
- Assign each letter two to four specific criteria, with the corroborating documents already in the file.
- Ask for one comparative sentence: where you rank against the discipline's top tier, in the writer's professional judgment.
- Brief with facts and metrics. Never draft the letter. Template language across letters is detectable and discounted.

The 30 / 90 / 180-day sprint

DAYS 0–30 — INVENTORY AND MAP

- Decide the field: athlete, coach, or transition case (Chapter 4). Everything downstream depends on this.
- Build the competition résumé: every event, level, result, and the document that proves it.
- Request federation records now — results, rankings, record certificates, selection documents. They are the long pole.
- Score yourself with the Chapter 12 matrix; identify your two anchors and two weakest criteria.

DAYS 31–90 — BUILD AND REQUEST

- Pursue officiating certification or a selection-committee appointment. Keep the invitation and the completion proof.
- Pitch two sports journalists a specific angle on your method or transition — not your next fixture.
- Order certified translations for every foreign-language federation record and press item.
- Assemble the earnings or prize-money percentile analysis.
- Send letter-writer briefing memos with documents attached.

DAYS 91–180 — PROVE AND ASSEMBLE

- Build the award dossiers (Chapter 5) and press cover sheets (Chapter 6).
- Build the entity reputation dossier and the but-for sentence (Chapter 7).

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- Build the ranking trajectory table with sources and interpretation (Chapter 8).
- Collect 6–8 letters; assemble exhibits numbered by criterion; then professional review, then file.

Strategy note — the patience rule

The most expensive mistake in EB-1A is filing three months early. Athletes feel the clock and rush. But federation records take weeks, translations take weeks, and a 90-day build converts maybes into exhibits. Denials cost more than patience — in money, in time, and in the record you carry into your next filing.

The bottom line

Results, standing, influence, recency. Prove all four and Step 2 answers itself.

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CHAPTER
10

Filing, Fees & Timing

Mechanics, money, and the one variable you do not control.



Timelines vary by case, service center, and country of chargeability — always check the current Visa Bulletin.

Figure 10.1 — The EB-1A journey, end to end.

The filing

EB-1A runs on **Form I-140**. A standalone I-140 can be filed online; if you file premium processing or other forms together, file by mail. Approval sets your **priority date** — your place in line, which controls everything after.

Costs

> **Snapshot — fees as verified July 2026**
>
> **Form I-140 filing fee:** $715
>
> **Asylum Program Fee (paid with the I-140):** $600 standard · $300 for small employers (25 or fewer full-time-equivalent employees — the bracket most individual self-petitioners fall into) · $0 for nonprofits. Paying the wrong tier causes rejection at intake.

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Premium processing (Form I-907, optional): 15-business-day adjudication window; a fee adjustment applies to filings postmarked on or after March 1, 2026 — currently $2,965 for the I-140.

Payment method: USCIS has moved away from paper checks and money orders for mailed filings — pay by card (G-1450) or ACH (G-1650) unless exempt.

Fees change. Confirm at uscis.gov/feecalculator and on the current Form G-1055 before you send anything.

Timing

- **Preparation:** 2–6 months of evidence building and drafting. The part you control, and the part that decides the outcome.
- **Adjudication:** 15 business days with premium processing; otherwise months, varying by service center. Premium buys speed, not favor — the standard is identical.
- **After approval:** Form I-485 (adjustment of status, if you are in the U.S. and your date is current) or consular processing abroad.

The Visa Bulletin

Snapshot — July 2026 Visa Bulletin (EB-1)

Worldwide, Mexico, Philippines: Current — no wait for a visa number.

China: Final Action Date of June 1, 2023 (advanced two months).

India: Final Action Date of October 15, 2022 — retrogressed two months; the Department of State has warned of possible further retrogression before the fiscal year ends September 30, 2026.

Context: EB-2 India is unavailable for the remainder of FY2026 — a principal reason Indian-born athletes, coaches, and sports professionals are moving toward EB-1A and filing early to secure a priority date.

A snapshot, not a forecast. Check travel.state.gov monthly — the bulletin is the most volatile fact in this guide.

Working with an attorney

This guide is designed to make you a better client, not to replace counsel. AiVass is not a law firm. What changes when you arrive prepared:

- You bring a criteria matrix and a competition résumé — the engagement starts at strategy, not triage.

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- Your evidence is already quantified and sourced, so billable hours go into argument, not chasing documents.
- You can evaluate a quote intelligently: a firm that cannot explain its Step-2 theory of your case is not the firm.

The bottom line

You control preparation quality and filing date. You do not control the bulletin. Build well, file when ready, verify fees and policy the week you send.

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CHAPTER

11

Expert & B2B Annex

For attorneys, paralegals, legal-ops teams, and in-house mobility.

This chapter is operational. It assumes professional familiarity with the standard and focuses on repeatable workflow for athletics-profile EB-1A matters: intake, assessment, gap remediation, exhibit architecture, and pre-filing QC.

Intake questionnaire — athletics profile

Section	What to capture	Why it matters
Field decision	Athlete, coach, or transition case; one-sentence field of endeavor with the level named	Prong 2 — the #1 structural error (Ch. 4)
Transition analysis	Recency of athletic acclaim; whether coaching acclaim is sustained at national level	Determines whether both records may be combined
Competition résumé	Every event: level, field size, result, proving document	Criterion 1 + Step 2 level evidence
Awards	Individual and team; document naming the beneficiary as recipient; award dossier	Criterion 1 — team awards now qualify with named receipt
Federation records	Results sheets, ranking history, record certificates, selection records	Step 2 — the decisive evidence in athletics
Roles	Club/federation/program standing; captaincy or coaching appointment; but-for outcome	Criterion 8, both prongs; § 204.5(g)(1) employer letters
Compensation	Contracts, prize-money lists, endorsements; comparator discipline and level	Criterion 9 — money lists give clean percentiles
Press	Full articles + author + date; outlet circulation or viewership; broadcast transcripts	Criterion 3
Judging	Officiating certifications, event assignments, selection-committee service, completion proof	Criterion 4

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Section	What to capture	Why it matters
Memberships	Halls of fame; athlete commissions; national-team selection policy and committee	Criterion 2
Translations	Certified translations for all foreign federation records and press	Regulatory requirement; long lead time
Recency	All recognition within the last 24 months	Sustained acclaim — the athletics pressure point

Criteria assessment matrix

Score each criterion twice — Step 1 (does the evidence objectively meet the regulatory terms?) and Step 2 (does it carry weight toward top-of-field?). A criterion can pass Step 1 and contribute almost nothing at Step 2.

#	Criterion	Step 1: met?	Step 2: weight	Gap / remediation	Owner	Due
1	Medals, titles & team awards					
8	Leading / critical role					
3	Published material					
9	Contracts & prize money					
2	Memberships / national team					
4	Judging & officiating					
5	Original contributions					
6	Sports science / comparable					

Exhibit index architecture

- Number by criterion: 3.1, 3.2 … 5.1, 5.2 … so any claim is verifiable in seconds.
- One cover sheet per exhibit: what it is, which criterion element it satisfies, what it proves.

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- Certified translations for every foreign federation record, certificate, and press item; full articles, never clippings.
- Web evidence captured with URL and access date visible in the capture.
- Order criterion sections by evidentiary strength — not regulatory order.

Pre-filing QC checklist

☐ Field decision made first: athlete, coach, or transition — and the evidence matches the intended U.S. work.

☐ Transition cases: recency of athletic acclaim and sustained national coaching acclaim both addressed explicitly.

☐ Field of endeavor stated identically in the cover letter, every criterion section, and every letter.

☐ Criterion 1: award dossier per prize; individual receipt documented for every team honor.

☐ Criterion 8: entity reputation dossier + but-for outcome with a number.

☐ Criterion 9: comparator discipline and competitive level verified; percentile shown with methodology.

☐ Criterion 3: outlet circulation or viewership documented; paid-placement screen complete.

☐ Criterion 4: completion proof, not invitations only.

☐ Ranking and record evidence filed with the ranking system explained and interpreted.

☐ Certified translations complete for all foreign-language exhibits.

☐ Letters: independent-majority, distinct voices, each claim corroborated by a document.

☐ Recency: documented recognition within the last 24 months.

☐ Fees verified on the current G-1055; Asylum Program Fee tier correct.

☐ Policy Manual updates page checked within 30 days of filing.

RFE risk register — athletics profiles

Prong 2: "the beneficiary's acclaim is as an athlete but the intended work is coaching." Remedy: the transition analysis, argued affirmatively in the initial filing.

Criterion 1: "award not shown to be nationally recognized" · "individual receipt of a team award not established." Remedy: award dossier + the document naming the beneficiary.

Criterion 8: "organization not shown distinguished" · "role not shown leading or critical." Remedy: reputation dossier + quantified but-for outcome.

Criterion 9: "comparison not to others in the field." Remedy: money list or league distribution for the same discipline and level.

Sustained acclaim: "acclaim not shown to be maintained." The signature athletics denial. Remedy:

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fill the last 24 months — coaching, officiating, federation roles, coverage.

Final merits: “meets criteria but record does not establish top of field.” Remedy: explain the sport’s competitive structure, then place the beneficiary in it with ranking and results percentiles.

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CHAPTER
12

Myths, Red Flags & Your Self-Assessment

Score the record you have. Then build the record you need.

Eight myths that keep qualified athletes from filing

The myth	The reality
“Only Olympic medalists qualify.”	The regulation asks for “lesser” nationally or internationally recognized awards — and awards are 1 of 10 criteria.
“Team medals don’t count.”	Since October 2024, USCIS states team awards can qualify where you are an actual named recipient.
“I can file as an athlete and work as a coach.”	Only under the transition rule’s conditions. Otherwise it is a Prong 2 problem (Ch. 4).
“Retired athletes are ineligible.”	Retirement is irrelevant. Sustained acclaim is not. Fill the last 24 months.
“My sport is too niche to show national acclaim.”	Prove it instead of conceding it: federation charters, olympic committee recognition, national championships, media coverage.
“I need a club or federation to sponsor me.”	No job offer is required. You self-petition.
“Rankings don’t matter — they’re not a criterion.”	They are Step 2 evidence, where officers consider any relevant material. In athletics they are often decisive.
“I’m too young.”	The Manual states a person may be very young and still show sustained acclaim; rookie awards are its own example.

Ten red flags to fix before you file

- ☐ A coach’s petition built entirely on a playing career, with no coaching acclaim.

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- ☐ An athlete's petition whose intended U.S. work is coaching — or the reverse.
- ☐ Team honors filed with a roster listing instead of a document naming you.
- ☐ Club, regional, or age-group titles presented as nationally recognized.
- ☐ Rankings asserted without a federation source and without explaining the system.
- ☐ Salary or prize money compared to a different sport, league, or country.
- ☐ Press files that are box scores, transfer rumors, or club-website posts.
- ☐ Officiating and judging claimed on invitations, with no proof of completion.
- ☐ Letters written by your agent, your coach, and your club — with no independent voice.
- ☐ No documented recognition within the last 24 months.

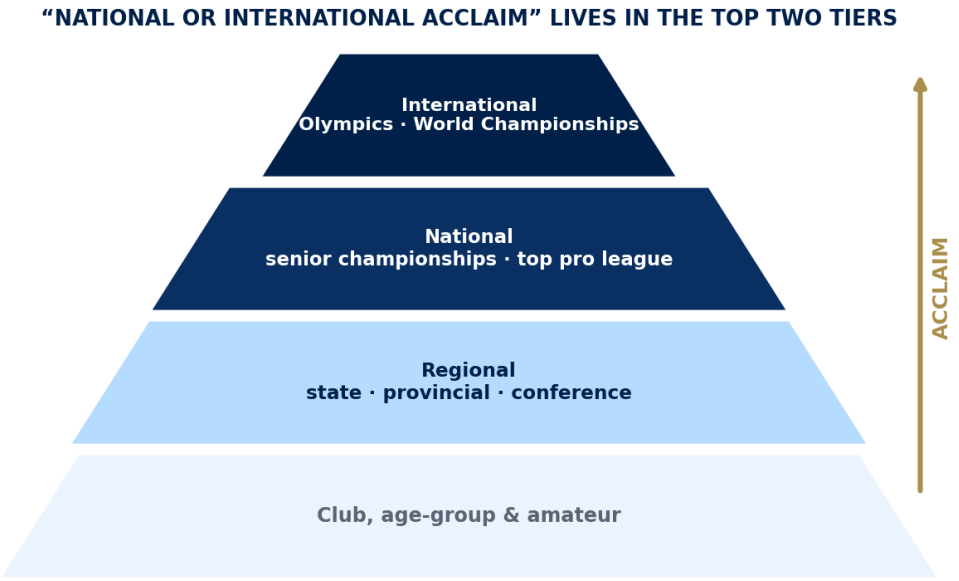
Case-positioning questions

Answer these in writing before you draft anything. If an answer has no federation document behind it, that is your next 90 days.

1. Are you filing as an athlete, a coach, or a transition case — and does your recent record match?
2. What is your highest documented competitive level, and which federation document proves it?
3. Which team honors name you individually, in a document from the awarding body?
4. What does your ranking or results trajectory show across the last three to five seasons?
5. Who covered you in national media in the last two seasons, and what is that outlet's reach?
6. Where does your contract or prize money sit against your discipline's published distribution?
7. Which distinguished club, program, or federation relied on you — and for what outcome?
8. If an officer asked you to name the top 3% of your discipline, could you? Are you among them, and why?

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The self-assessment scorecard



Youth, rookie, and amateur awards can still qualify if nationally recognized — prove the recognition.

Figure 12.1 — Where your record sits. Score honestly: if the federation document is not in your folder, it does not exist.

Component	Points	Your score
Three or more criteria fully evidenced (documents in hand)	30	
National or international competitive level proven by federation sources	15	
Team awards documented with individual receipt	10	
Correct field selected — athlete, coach, or transition — and evidence matches	10	
Documented recognition within the last 24 months	15	
Compensation or prize-money percentile documented	10	
Six to eight letter writers identified, independent-majority	10	
Total	100	

Score	Where you stand	What to do next
75–100	Strong. Anchors evidenced, field decision correct, recency intact.	Assemble exhibits and seek professional review. Your remaining work is curation and narrative.

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Score	Where you stand	What to do next
50–74	Buildable. The foundation is real; the proof has gaps.	Run the 90/180-day sprint (Chapter 9) against your weakest criteria. Do not file yet.
30–49	Early. Real competitive achievement, insufficient national acclaim.	Spend 12–24 months building: officiating certification, selection committees, national press, coaching appointments. Evaluate EB-2 NIW in parallel with counsel.
Below 30	Not yet.	This is information, not a verdict. Build the record, or discuss other categories with an attorney.

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Where to Go From Here

This field guide sits inside the AiVass EB-1A library. Each companion product goes deep on one stage of the build.

Product	Best for	What it does
EB-1A Master Guide	Everyone	The full legal framework and all ten criteria — the foundation of this series.
Eligibility Self-Assessment Workbook	Beginners	Extends Chapter 12 into a full scored diagnostic with decision paths.
Evidence Mapping Workbook	DIY applicants	Turns the criteria masterclasses into a working evidence-to-criteria system.
Field of Endeavor Definition Guide	Professionals	Drills Chapter 4's formula — including the athlete-versus-coach decision.
Recommendation Letter Toolkit	Applicants & lawyers	Briefing memos, independence hierarchy, corroboration mapping.
Personal Statement Framework	Applicants	Structures intent, future U.S. work, and national benefit.
Petition Assembly Checklist	DIY applicants	Chapter 11's QC pass, exhibit by exhibit.
100 AI Prompts for EB-1A	Everyone	The prompt library for inventory, mapping, gap-scan, and quantification.
Law Firm Toolkit (B2B)	Immigration firms	Intake, criteria matrices, RFE risk register, team workflow at volume.

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Sources & Verification

Every legal statement in this guide traces to a primary authority below. All sources were accessed and verified on **July 8, 2026**. Practitioner commentary, where it informed context, is identified as secondary and non-authoritative.

Source	Publisher	Authority	What it governs here
USCIS Policy Manual, Vol. 6, Part F, Ch. 2 — Extraordinary Ability	USCIS	Primary — agency guidance	Eligibility, the ten criteria, comparable evidence, two-step analysis, final merits, letters, and the athlete-to-coach transition rule.
8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h) and § 204.5(g)(1)	GPO / NARA	Primary — regulation	Definition of extraordinary ability, the ten criteria, comparable evidence, self-petition, employer-letter requirement.
INA § 203(b)(1)(A) · 8 U.S.C. § 1153(b)(1)(A)	U.S. Congress	Primary — statute	The three prongs: acclaim, continuing work, substantial benefit.
Employment-Based Immigration: First Preference EB-1 · uscis.gov	USCIS	Primary — agency	Self-petition confirmation; no PERM requirement.
Form I-140 page & instructions · Fee Schedule G-1055 · Fee Calculator	USCIS	Primary — agency	Filing mechanics, fees, Asylum Program Fee tiers, payment methods.
Policy Alerts, Sept. 12, 2023 and Oct. 2, 2024	USCIS	Primary — policy	Team awards may qualify with named receipt; past memberships count; scope of published material.
Kazarian v. USCIS, 596 F.3d 1115 (9th Cir. 2010)	9th Circuit	Primary — judicial	The two-step evidentiary analysis applied nationwide.
Visa Bulletin, July 2026	U.S. Dep't of State	Primary — agency	Priority dates and retrogression. Volatile: re-check monthly.
17 U.S.C. § 105 · Georgia v. Public.Resource.Org (2020)	Congress / SCOTUS	Primary	Public-domain status of U.S. government works and legal edicts.
Immigration law-firm alerts and practitioner commentary (2024–2026)	Various	Secondary — non-authoritative	Context and cross-confirmation only. Never the basis of a legal statement in this guide.

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Final reminder

This guide is educational. It is not legal advice, and AiVass LLC is not a law firm. Before filing, have a licensed U.S. immigration attorney review your petition, and verify every fee, date, and policy statement at uscis.gov. Guidance changes; your case deserves current law.

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